Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on William Shakespeare's Sonnet 34

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's shift in tone in William Shakespeare's "[Why didst thou promise such a beauteous day]" include

assonance,
apostrophe,
chiasmus,
consonance,
denotation,
diction,
elision,
epiphany,
metaphor,
rhetorical question,
rhyme scheme,
sigmatism,
tone, and
volta.

The contestant should recognize a logical—bordering on emotional—turn that characterizes the sonnet's concluding couplet. Recognition of an implied epiphany—arguably on either the speaker's or the listener's/the lover's part—in the "Ah!" (line 13) might inform the contestant's analysis.

The sonnet's third quatrain suggests a possibility that the lover/offender is aware of the pain they have caused/are causing and, perhaps, that the offender is sorrowful (line 11).

The final two lines frame something in the way of a forgiving of the offender for their display of tears.